PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Jeep CJ-8 Scrambler

1981–1986 · CJ-8 · Scrambler

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust in the long tub**
  Check the rockers, the rear corners of the bed, the wheel wells, under the roll bar and the floor. Jeep-CJ.com warns that patches welded over rust become rust. Knock on panels to find filler. Replacement Scrambler tubs exist, but they are a full strip-down job.
- [ ] **Frame and shock towers**
  Inspect the whole frame, especially the shackle mounts, the area behind the rear wheels and the body mounts. On 1982–86 wide-track trucks, Jeep-CJ.com says the shock towers can trap water. Mud blocks the drain holes in the boxed rails.
- [ ] **Steering box mount**
  Boxed frames often crack around the steering box, especially on lifted trucks with big tires. Look for cracks, fresh welds and movement when someone turns the wheel.
- [ ] **Engine choice**
  SlashGear calls the 258 six the most desirable engine. Jeep-CJ.com says to avoid the Iron Duke four. Look for start-up smoke, rattles, and oil weeping from the rear main seal.
- [ ] **Five-speed health**
  On 1985–86 trucks, check that the T-5 doesn't jump out of gear or grind. Jeep-CJ.com members call it weak. A T-176 swap is the common fix, and the driveshafts must be modified for length.
- [ ] **Tailgate, tops and seals**
  Check the tailgate hardware and weatherstripping and the cowl seals, since failed seals trap water. Tops and half cabs are Scrambler-specific, so price in a replacement if they're missing.
- [ ] **Originality and paperwork**
  Jeep-CJ.com recommends mostly stock trucks over projects or heavy trail builds. 4WDrive's featured truck came with a binder documenting its restoration, and paperwork like that matters on a truck this valuable.
- [ ] **Test drive**
  Start it cold. Test every gear, 4WD high and low on gravel, the brakes (gently at first), the gauges and the heater. Check for leaks at the transfer case and both axles.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Left tie-rod end fatigue crack**
  1984 · NHTSA 88V-009

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Wheelbase and body**
  103.5 in wheelbase versus the CJ-7's 93.5 in, same 55 in windshield and front end, with a longer rear overhang and a pickup-style box formed by the tub rather than a separate bed.

- [ ] **VIN**
  On the 17-character VIN, characters 6–7 read 88 for a CJ-8 (87 is a CJ-7). The 4th character is the engine (B = 151 Iron Duke, C = 258 six, U = AMC 150 four; per Offroaders.com and ExtremeTerrain) and the 10th the model year (B = 1981 … G = 1986).
- [ ] **VIN plate vs frame**
  Check the riveted firewall tag against the partial VIN on the passenger-side frame rail above the rear wheel; a CJ-7 tag on a Scrambler frame, or the reverse, means a rebuild.
- [ ] **Postal and export Scramblers**
  230 right-hand-drive automatics with a full-length steel 'World Cab' hardtop and barn-door rear went to the Alaska Postal Service; the export CJ8 Overlander (Venezuela, Australia) also used full-length rear windows.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/jeep/cj-8/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks